

DESIGN THINKING PROJECT • LIVE PRESENTATION



HELP HEROES

From Apology to Belonging: A Design Thinking Journey



James • Help Hero

Badge 001 "First Help" • Aug 2026



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German University of Digital Science



Overview hub

Start at the hub: all weeks



THE DESIGN CHALLENGE

Redesign the online learning experience for first-generation university students in a world in which access to high-speed internet is unreliable.



James to Professor

Subject: Sorry for late submission 23:47 • 1 bar



Sorry Professor, network failed again.
Sorry to bother you.
I understand if you deduct marks.

James

! Attachment failed • draft lost on timeout

THAT INBOX IS MY BRIEF

One mail. Three sorrys. A lost draft at night.

☾ After 11 pm, shared line

📶 Weak signal, lost work

It means James does not write that mail again.



Week 1: Wicked Problem

Knot, prism, iceberg, five definitions



UNDERSTANDING THE USER: JAMES

I met **James**, a first-generation student who has learned to **apologize**, for late work, for missed meetings, for needing help, and who has internalized the belief that he is a burden to the system.

I was inspired to discover that he **desperately wants to ask for help** but does not even know what to ask, because the institutional knowledge that some of his peers inherited from their families is a foreign language to him.

It's all about helping James **navigate and belong** without feeling like an outsider who has to apologize for existing.



James, 20

Second-year • The Sharing Student

 5 people • 1 connection

 Studies after 11 pm

 Signal  2 of 4

 Missed deadlines to timeouts



KEY INSIGHT: HIS WORDS

I want to ask for help, but I don't even know what to ask. I don't know what I don't know.

So he apologizes instead of asking. Built for that moment.



Week 3: Interviews

Maria...James...Aisha in their words





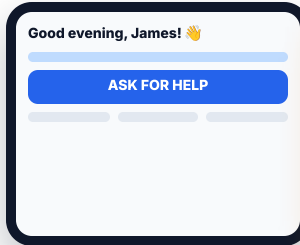
04 • THE SOLUTION

THE SOLUTION: HELP HEROES

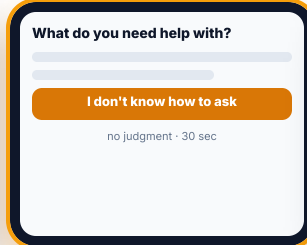
A program that reframes help-seeking as a strength

"Turning Questions into Connections"

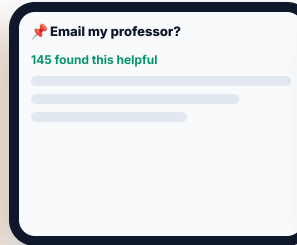
THE FLOW: ALL 5 PROTOTYPE SCREENS, 375×812



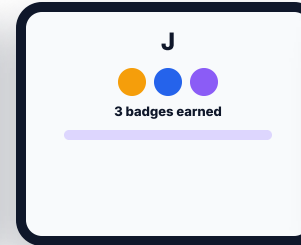
1 · Home



2 · Ask ★



3 · Help Wall



4 · Profile



5 · Community

Start with James tapping Ask ★. Rest is proof. Shame-free, ~2 KB/post.



Live prototype

Tap through Help Heroes



WHY IT WORKS FOR JAMES



Can't phrase it → "I don't know" button

We help him phrase it in 30 sec, no judgment. As James said in interview: "I don't know what I don't know."



Alone → anonymous Help Wall

145 students shared his question about emailing a professor. "I don't feel so alone" (Maria, testing)



Shame → Help Hero badges

"A reward for being brave enough to ask" (James, on badges). Pride replaces apology.



No data → text-only + offline

~2 KB/post. 12 Qs · 48 KB saved, auto-syncs on library wifi. "Almost no data" (Maria, on text-only)

Belonging, not just bandwidth → tested next.

TESTED WITH MARIA & JAMES

M

Maria, 19
Rural · library WiFi · 1st-year

J

James, 20
Shared device · 2nd-year

KEY FINDINGS • 2 USERS × 60 MIN

- ✓ Top find: ask-button to Home
- ✓ Pride validated: badges reward bravery
- ✓ Low-data validated: wall plus offline works

WHAT THEY SAID: VERBATIM

"Oh, that's me! That's exactly how I feel." (Maria, pointing at Ask)

"It's like it was designed for me." (James, pointing at the wall)

→ **Home CTA** ✓

Do not bury the best bit

→ **Offline + dark** ✓

12 Qs, less than one photo



Testing board

Findings from Maria + James



Iterated prototype

Week 7, built from feedback



NEXT STEPS → THANK YOU

WHERE THIS GOES NEXT

- 1 Give us 1 course plus 1 library slot for 4 weeks to pilot with 1 faculty and IT
- 2 Library hubs with offline packs, wider testing
- 3 Safety beyond badges, funding and moderation

How might we help first-generation students navigate without feeling like outsiders who apologize?

Thank You

HELP HEROES

Turning Questions into Connections



James • Help Hero

3 badges • paying it forward



*"Because when we ask for help,
we don't just find answers, we find each other."*

Augustine Atta Abrefa • s-01141 • Sep 2026



Try the prototype live

Happy to demo after Q&A



Isolation → Fear → Hope → Courage → Belonging